the Kannada film *KGF* and Prabhas's *Radhe Shyam* are some of the films vying for nationwide reach. Shah himself hopes to release another Telugu film—Mahesh Babu's *Sarkaru Vaari Paata*.

Over the past two years, with OTT's rise in popularity, cinema from the South has asserted itself. Both Amazon Prime and Netflix released a steady flow of Tamil, Telugu and Malayalam films with subtitles and, in some cases, dubbed versions in Hindi.

REMAKE EXPRESS

Filmmakers in Mumbai have been turning to the South for inspiration since the 1970s, which has contributed to the success of actors like Jeetendra, Mithun Chakraborty, Anil Kapoor, Govinda, Salman Khan, Ajay Devgn and Akshay Kumar. But this trend has revved up in the past few years. Shahid Kapoor saw his fortunes rise with *Kabir Singh*, a remake of the Telugu film *Arjun Reddy*. His next, *Jersey*, too, is a remake of a Telugu film.

Over the next few years, Bollywood is looking to remake around 24 Tamil, Telugu and Malayalam films, some featuring stars like Akshay Kumar (*Driving Licence*, Malayalam) and Salman Khan (*Master*, Tamil). There is good reason to redo them too, since they are "unabashed and unapologetic, multi-genre entertainers with little bit of comedy, action, drama and family emotion", says cinema owner and exhibitor Akshaye Rathi. "In Hindi we have, more often than not, started making single-genre films...[and] the emotion and storytelling device has become too urban and niche."

This time around, there is also a concerted effort by the Hindi industry to go beyond the usual formula. Applause Entertainment is revisiting critically acclaimed Tamil film *Aruvi*, while Aanand L. Rai has produced *Good Luck Jerry*, which relocates the Nayanthara-starrer *Kolamaavu Kokila* to Punjab with Janhvi Kapoor in the lead. Vikram Malhotra, founder and CEO of Abundantia Entertainment, has bought the rights to not just *Soorarai Pottru* (Tamil), the most watched film on Amazon Prime in 2020, but also two acclaimed Malayalam films—*Angamaly Diaries* and *#Home*. "Good films will always find adaptations because they have the ability to connect with a universal audience without losing their emotional relevance," says Malhotra. He finds that the creators in the South are "more willing to put themselves out there and back their conviction" and, especially in Malayalam cinema, "the risk-taking ability is higher, therefore the ability to create fresher concepts and disruptive stories is higher".



VIKRAM VEDHA
Saif Ali Khan and Hrithik Roshan team up for the second time in a remake of this acclaimed Tamil film featuring R. Madhavan and Vijay Sethupathi



SELFIEE
Yet another Prithviraj film gets a Hindi spin. Akshay Kumar and Emraan Hashmi star in this remake of the Malayalam comedy-drama *Driving Licence*



"IN MALAYALAM CINEMA, THE RISK-TAKING ABILITY IS HIGHER, SO THE ABILITY TO CREATE DISRUPTIVE STORIES IS HIGHER"

VIKRAM MALHOTRA
Founder & CEO, Abundantia Entertainment

Instead of "remakes", Malhotra prefers the term "adaptations". "For me, it is less about literally remaking the film and more about reimagining its soul and sentiment," he says. Director Jagan Shakti (of *Mission Mangal* fame), who will be directing the Hindi remake of the hit Malayalam drama *Ayyappanum Koshiyum*, concurs. "It is important to adapt to the milieu that it is set in," he says. "The best way for me is to alter and stretch the original, but not touch the soul of the script." Shakti, who hails from Bengaluru, feels that his ability to converse in Tamil, Telugu, Kannada and Malayalam puts him in an advantageous position "to approach and understand" the original better.

It also helps if the director of the original is up to redoing his work in a new language. In the case of *Vikram Vedha* and *HIT: The First Case*, producer Bhushan Kumar of T-Series thought it apt that the duo Pushkar-Gayathri and Sailesh Kolanu direct the Hindi version since "they know the characters, storyline and treatment like the back of their hand". For Kumar, who roped in *Arjun Reddy* writer-director Sandeep Reddy Vanga for the Hindi remake, it's "not neces-